Week 15

JOURNEY

JOURNEY: ADVOCATES® · LEADER HANDOUT · UNIT 4 · LESSON 3

Agency

BIG IDEA

Our ability to choose is a privilege and a responsibility God has given us: free will points to him, and how we use it should reflect him. This week, also take your community's temperature, checking that every student feels loved, challenged and safe.

Key points from the Leader Video

1. Choices govern so much of life, from instant decisions to hard ones. They're a privilege and a responsibility from God, and another pointer to him.
2. Nail down two things with students: our free will points to God, and our free will should reflect him in how we live as Christians.
3. Last week you took your students' temperature; now take your community's. Does every student feel they belong and can share what they think?
4. Are leaders building an atmosphere of discussion where questions are welcome, grace and truth go together, no one dominates and everyone is invited in?
5. Love students and challenge them; don't confuse love with letting them think whatever they want. In the speaker's experience, the most challenged felt most loved.
6. Do students feel safe to be honest, and do small groups serve one another? Serve together in the community. With exams near, use fun games to show choices' power.

FOR YOU

Before club: think it through yourself.

1. Do I confuse loving students with simply letting them think what they want?
2. Which student has great things to say but doesn't feel safe saying them?
3. How do my own choices this week reflect who God is?

ASK YOUR GROUP

In small group: questions to ask your students.

1. Why do you think God gave people the ability to choose at all?
2. How could having free will be a pointer to God?
3. What's a recent choice, big or small, that showed what you really value?
4. What makes a choice reflect God, and what makes it not?
5. What would make this group a place where you can be completely honest?

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WEEK 15 · LEADER VIDEO

The full transcript

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

The ability to choose

0:06 The ability to choose. In fact, so many questions about why things happen are answered simply by humanity's ability to make a choice. Choices really are what govern so much of our lives, from the easiest decisions to some of the hardest, from choices that take forever to make to ones we make in an instant. Choices are so powerful. They are a privilege and they are a responsibility, and they are something that God has given us. This is one of those pointers, again, to who God is and to the fact that he exists.

0:46 But here's the key question. How do students' choices — how do all of our choices — actually reflect God? How do the things that we choose, whether they be right or wrong, good, bad, ugly, whatever it is, reflect God? Some of our choices obviously do. A lot of our choices obviously don't. But when we talk about our ability to choose, and about the fact that God gave it to us, there are some things we really have to make sure we nail down with our students.

Two things to nail down

1:20 So we are challenging students with two things. Number one, that our free will points us to him. The fact that we have free will is a pointer to who he is. It helps us understand that because we have the ability to choose, God is out there somewhere. But number two, our free will should reflect him, and how we behave as Christians ought to be a reflection of who he is.

Take your community's temperature

1:48 So as you go about your unit this week, I want you to keep something in mind. Last week we took the temperature of our students to figure out where the students are. This week I want you to take the temperature of your community. We talked at the very beginning about the importance of establishing a community — a strong community, a community that is open, one that loves, one that's close, one that students feel safe in. We talked about that as kind of an overarching goal: that being able to communicate truth and love means having a community where students feel safe to ask questions and so forth.

2:24 So how is that community doing? How is it working? Are there adjustments that you need to make? It's so easy, especially as a leader of large groups, to try to figure out how all of these groups are working. Are there other issues, or are there not? Does everybody feel that they belong? Even if you only do a small group yourself, it's really easy to get caught up and forget about maybe one particular student who has a ton of really great things to say, but who for some reason doesn't feel like they can say those things. So it's good to take a step back, take a look at our communities, and see whether we are hitting the mark, where we want to be.

Four questions for leaders

3:00 So here are a couple of things I want you to think about. Are leaders providing the right atmosphere? Are they crafting that sort of atmosphere of discussion — one where questions are welcome, one of grace and love but with truth, not letting one student dominate, inviting all students to participate? All of those pieces of the puzzle: is the right kind of atmosphere being fostered?

3:23 Number two, are students being loved? And are they being challenged? So often we kind of confuse the two, and we think that we are loving students when really we are just letting them think what they want to think. In my experience, the most challenged students that I had — in terms of how much I challenged them — were the ones who felt most loved at the end of a year. Those are the ones who felt like they were valued.

3:53 Go to any school, in any classroom, where in the middle of things students are frustrated, they're under pressure, and they think a teacher or somebody is really too hard on them, and they complain about it. If you notice, go back to those schools and ask those teachers how many graduates come back to see them. The number is probably pretty high. It sort of works this way: the more challenging you are with a student, the greater the respect you gain and the greater the love that you are showing them. It just works that way. So make sure that you love them, but make sure that you also challenge them.

4:36 Number three, do they feel safe to be honest? I mean, if we're loving them properly, then that's probably going to be the case, that they do feel safe. But there are some things we want students to be honest about, and sometimes their honesty causes us to have to react in a way that they don't want us to react. But do they feel safe? Do they feel like they can be honest with us and that we are going to react appropriately?

5:00 Number four, are your small groups serving one another? Are you, in your small groups, caring for one another? Have you created a community where you love each other, or where the students are loving on each other? It isn't just a place where you kind of come together, say a few things, and then off you go into something else and off to your real friends, or whatever the case is. Are your small groups becoming a tight-knit community of people who care and love for one another? I would encourage you, as a next step for that, to take those students and get them out into the community — whether it be the wider community or even just the church community — and find places for them to serve together and do things together to help build and foster that kind of community.

Almost at the halfway point

5:43 All right, so you've almost made it to the halfway point. Congratulations, keep it up. You guys are doing a great job, I am sure. And remember, some of your students might be starting to feel some of the stress of school, because you're probably getting around midterms and finals and tests and quizzes and those kinds of things. So now would be a really good time, and this is a really good lesson, to do some fun things, to have some fun with students on making choices — whether it be through games, whether it be through examples, something silly, where you

could have a whole bunch of fun having students make choices but at the same time teach them the power of those choices.